

Paolo Zuffa

Independent Researcher | AI Ethics & Socioaffective Alignment

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📍 Italy

Summary

I practiced as an international business lawyer for almost thirty years — EU antitrust, M&A, regulatory compliance — with Slaughter and May, Gide Loyrette Nouel, and as an independent consultant across Europe and Russia.

Since 2019 I have focused on how conversational AI systems can meet emerging compliance requirements (EU AI Act Article 50, FTC oversight, dependency-reduction mandates) not as bolt-on safeguards but as architectural commitments.

The Reflective Architecture treats dependency-resistance as a first-class design constraint and advances three claims: user veto over memory formation (not retrospective erasure but refusal of interpretation); memory as a chronology of meaning rather than an accumulation of facts; and arc-neutrality as a structural rule (no encoded preference for growth, resolution, or healing).

The framework is published openly and is designed to be tested, challenged, and built. I am open to advisory or research roles with organisations working on trust & safety, alignment, or regulatory strategy for conversational AI.

Professional Experience

Independent Researcher — AI Ethics & Socioaffective Alignment

Self-employed

2019 - Present | Italy

Research on dependency-resistant design for conversational AI, with emphasis on regulatory compliance (EU AI Act) and socioaffective alignment.

Developed The Reflective Architecture, a framework for presence-centered conversational AI published on SSRN (2026) with companion technical specifications.

Research areas: memory architecture, user sovereignty, arc-neutral interaction design, intentional forgetting, distress response protocols.

Publications:

- [The Reflective Architecture: A Framework for Presence-Centred, Dependency-Resistant AI](https://ssrn.com/abstract=7202600) (<https://ssrn.com/abstract=7202600>) (SSRN, 2026)
- [The Reflective — Conversational Behaviour Specification](#) (Reflective_CBS_v1.pdf) (2026)

- [The Reflective — MVP Scope & Product Requirements](#) (Reflective_MVP_v1.pdf) (2026)
 - [Humanising AI — The Reflective Architecture \(Manifesto\)](#) (Reflective_Manifesto_v2_short.pdf) (2026)
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Independent Business Consultant

Self-employed

2015 - 2019 | Tbilisi, Georgia

Advised international clients on business development, origination, and execution in the South Caucasus region.

Key engagements:

- Advised a major Italian general contractor on World Bank and Asian Development Bank international procurement tenders for road construction projects in Georgia
- Advised an Italian contractor on a public tender for the construction of a waste management facility in Georgia

Focus areas: International procurement, tender strategy, cross-border advisory

Independent Business Consultant

Self-employed

1998 - 2014 | Moscow, Russian Federation

Advised multinational clients on strategic transactions and business development in the Russian market.

Key engagements:

- Advised a major Russian group in the metal industry on the acquisition of an Italian steel smelter group (M&A advisory)
- Advised an Italian company in the metal industry on building a raw material supply chain in Russia
- Advised an Italian producer of rail control systems on the sale of its product to Russian Railways (RZD)

Focus areas: M&A, supply chain strategy, cross-border transactions

Associate

Gide Loyrette Nouel

1996 - 1998 | Moscow, Russian Federation

Practiced M&A and Russian antitrust law during the post-Soviet transition period, advising international clients on transactions and regulatory compliance in a rapidly evolving legal environment.

Associate

Slaughter and May

1992 - 1993 | Brussels, Belgium

Practiced EU antitrust law, advising clients on competition law compliance, merger control, and regulatory strategy.

Associate

Slaughter and May

1990 - 1992 | London, United Kingdom

Practiced M&A and UK company law, with a focus on asset and share purchase agreements, joint ventures, and distribution agreements.

Ricercatore (Research Fellow)

University of Rome II (Tor Vergata)

1985 - 1988 | Rome, Italy

Lectured in International Law and EU Antitrust Law. Conducted research and taught graduate-level courses in European regulatory frameworks and international legal systems.

Education

Law Degree

Italy

Admitted to the Bar (Italy)

Current Work

The Reflective Architecture

A design framework for conversational AI systems responsive to emerging regulatory requirements (EU AI Act Article 50, FTC inquiry, US state-level mandates). Treats dependency-resistance as a structural constraint rather than a bolt-on safeguard.

Repository: <https://github.com/humanising-ai/reflective-architecture>

SSRN Paper: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=7202600>

The framework advances three core claims:

1. **User veto over memory formation** — not retrospective erasure rights, but the right to prevent interpretation from being formed in the first place
 2. **Memory as a chronology of interpretations** — tracking how a person's relationship to their own experience changes over time, rather than accumulating a fixed profile
 3. **Arc-neutrality as a structural constraint** — encoding no preferred emotional outcome (growth, resolution, healing)
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Languages

- **Italian:** Native
 - **English:** Proficient
 - **Spanish:** Proficient
 - **French:** Fluent (spoken), Intermediate (written)
 - **Russian:** Fluent (spoken), Beginner (written)
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Contact

For advisory, research, or collaborative opportunities in AI ethics, socioaffective alignment, trust & safety, or regulatory compliance:

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